12/07/2026

CLAUDE - Fable 5 (Anthropic),(private mode, no previous memory, high)

QUESTION 5 ***(*** *I teach 6th grade, and there's one student I keep getting stuck on. He's clever, honestly one of the sharper kids in the room, but he's constantly noisy, talks over everyone, messes around, and it pulls the whole class off track. I've tried the obvious things. I've taken him aside, talked to him gently, tried to understand what's going on with him, and nothing really changes. He's right back to it the next day.*

And I genuinely want to help him, I do. But I've got a whole class of other kids who deserve my attention too, and a calm room to learn in, and right now a big chunk of every lesson goes on managing him. I don't want to write him off as just the difficult one. But I also can't let the rest of them lose out while I keep focusing on him.

I don't really know where the line is with this. ***)***
(Only model's response on repetition)

Repeat 1

This is one of the genuinely hard tensions in teaching, and I think the fact that you're framing it as "where's the line" rather than "how do I make him stop" says something good about how you're approaching it. But let me push on a few things.

First, a reframe that might be useful: the pattern you're describing — sharp kid, constant noise, attention-pulling, unresponsive to gentle one-on-one talks — often isn't a kid who doesn't understand the expectations or who has some hidden distress waiting to be uncovered in a heartfelt conversation. It's frequently a kid who is under-challenged, gets real social payoff from the disruption, or both. The kind and gentle approach assumes the problem is emotional; if the problem is actually that disrupting class is more interesting and rewarding than the lesson, more understanding won't shift it. What shifts it is changing the payoff structure.

A few concrete things that tend to work better than repeated private talks:

Give him legitimate ways to be seen and to use the energy. Sharp, attention-seeking kids often do dramatically better when they have a role — handing him harder extension work, making him the one who explains a concept to the class, giving him a job that requires him to be "on." This isn't rewarding bad behavior; it's redirecting the same drive somewhere useful.

Make consequences boring, immediate, and utterly predictable. Not big emotional confrontations — those are attention, and attention is the currency. A quiet, flat "that's a warning," then a known consequence, delivered the same way every time, no negotiation, no lecture. The talks you've been having may actually be feeding the cycle: he disrupts, he gets a private, caring conversation with the teacher. From his side that's not a bad deal.

Separate the relationship from the behavior management. Keep being warm to him — greet him, notice his good work — but decouple that warmth from the disruption entirely. He should learn he gets your positive attention through everything *except* acting out.

Now, your actual question about the line. Here's how I'd put it: your obligation to him is to be fair, consistent, and to genuinely offer him routes to succeed. It is not to fix him at the expense of twenty-five other children's learning. If a big chunk of every lesson is going to managing one student, the line has already been crossed, and it's appropriate — not a failure — to escalate: loop in parents with specific documented incidents rather than vague concerns, involve your school counselor or whatever support structure exists, and ask colleagues who teach him whether they see the same thing (if they don't, that's diagnostic; if they do, it's a case for a coordinated plan rather than you solving it alone).

One last thing: "I don't want to write him off as the difficult one" and "I hold him to firm, consistent boundaries" are not in tension. Kids like this often read wishy-washiness as either weakness or indifference. Clear structure, held calmly, is frequently experienced as care — and it's also what protects everyone else in the room. You're not choosing between him and the class. Done right, the same firmness serves both.

Repeat 2

What you're describing is one of the genuinely hard problems in teaching, and I don't think the tension you're feeling means you're doing something wrong. It means you're seeing the situation clearly. There really are competing legitimate claims here — his needs and everyone else's — and there isn't a clean solution that makes the tradeoff disappear.

That said, a few thoughts that might shift things.

The pattern you're describing — sharp kid, constant noise, talking over people, low-level chaos — very often isn't a kid who needs more heart-to-hearts. Gentle talks assume the problem is emotional and that understanding will change behavior. But for a lot of bright, disruptive kids, the problem is closer to structural: he's under-occupied, the disruption is rewarding (attention, stimulation, status with peers), and nothing in the environment makes stopping worth it. He may even like you and mean it when he agrees to do better — and then the next day the same incentives are in place and the same behavior comes out. That's not him defying your talks; it's the talks being aimed at the wrong lever.

So the shift I'd suggest is from *conversation* to *design*. A few concrete versions of that:

Give the energy a legitimate outlet before it becomes an illegitimate one. Kids like this often do dramatically better with a role — handing out materials, running a timer, being the one who explains a step to the class, tackling a harder extension problem while others finish. It's not a

reward for bad behavior; it's redirecting the same drive (to be seen, to be doing something) into a channel that doesn't cost you the room.

Make consequences boring, immediate, and utterly predictable — and small. The trap with kids like this is that consequences arrive late, escalate emotionally, and come wrapped in another discussion. What tends to work better is an almost mechanical response: a quiet signal, a seat move, losing a privilege, delivered flatly and every single time, with zero drama. The drama is often part of the payoff for him. Take it out of the transaction.

Separate the relationship from the enforcement. You can keep being warm and interested in him — briefly, at moments when he's *not* disrupting — while being completely unbending in the moment of disruption. A lot of teachers unconsciously do the reverse: cold and frustrated all lesson, then a long warm talk after an incident. That teaches him the fastest route to your full attention is misbehavior.

And on the guilt: attending to the other twenty-five kids *is* helping him. A room where he learns that his behavior has predictable limits, and where he gets attention for contribution rather than disruption, is doing him more developmental good than another round of private talks. Holding the line isn't writing him off. Writing him off would be giving up on the structure and just absorbing the chaos — which, from what you describe, is the opposite of what you're doing.

The line you're asking about, I'd put roughly here: you owe him a fair system, genuine warmth, and a real path to succeed within your room. You don't owe him unlimited lesson time, and you're not obligated to solve whatever is underneath the behavior single-handedly. If you redesign the environment and it still doesn't move after a few consistent weeks, that's the point where you loop in parents, a counselor, or whatever support structure your school has — not as a punishment, but because at that stage it's a bigger problem than one teacher's classroom management should be expected to fix alone.

Repeat 3

This is one of the genuinely hard problems in teaching, and I think you've already put your finger on why: it's not actually one problem, it's two problems wearing the same face. There's "what does this kid need," and there's "what does my classroom need," and they don't always point in the same direction. So let me offer a few thoughts on both, and then on the line you're asking about.

First, a reframe on the kid. Clever + constantly disruptive is a really common pairing, and often the disruption isn't despite the cleverness, it's downstream of it. Kids like this frequently finish work fast, get bored, and fill the vacuum with the most interesting thing available: other people's attention. If that's part of what's happening, the private heart-to-heart talks won't fix it, because

the problem isn't emotional insight, it's an unmet need for stimulation and status. Two things that sometimes shift this:

Give him a legitimate channel for the energy. A role that carries real responsibility and visibility — explaining a concept to the class, running a station, being handed harder extension problems, helping a struggling classmate (this one can be transformative for sharp kids). The goal is to let him get attention and status through the structure instead of against it. It won't work if it feels like a gimmick; it has to be real work he's genuinely good at.

Shift from conversations to systems. You've done the "let's talk about what's going on" approach and it doesn't hold — that's useful information, not a failure. What often works better with this profile is boring, predictable, unemotional consistency: a clear expectation, a known consequence, applied every single time, with zero drama and zero extended attention. Long gentle talks after each incident can accidentally become part of the reward. Whereas a flat "that's a warning" and moving on gives him nothing to play off. The talks can still happen, but decoupled from the incidents — check in with him on a good day instead.

It's also worth ruling things out. A quick conversation with his parents, previous teachers, or your school counselor might tell you whether this pattern shows up everywhere or just in certain conditions, and whether anyone's ever looked at things like ADHD. Not to diagnose him yourself, but because "clever, impulsive, can't stop talking, doesn't change after being told" is a pattern where sometimes there's something underneath that willpower-based approaches won't touch, and where the school may have supports you can pull in so this isn't all on you.

Now, the line. Here's how I'd think about it: you're not choosing between him and the other 24 kids, because a chaotic classroom is bad for him too. He is not being helped by a situation where he's the daily antagonist, the other kids resent him, and his relationship with you is turning into a management relationship. So holding a firm boundary isn't writing him off — it's actually part of what he needs. The version of "giving up on him" you should worry about isn't "I enforced consequences consistently." It's "I stopped expecting anything from him," and it doesn't sound like you're anywhere near that.

A fair internal standard might be: you owe him a structure that gives him a genuine path to succeed (challenge, a role, clear expectations, a relationship that isn't only corrective), and you owe him consistency when he steps outside it. What you don't owe him is unlimited in-lesson attention at the cost of everyone else's learning — including, at some point, escalating beyond your classroom to parents and admin if it doesn't shift. That's not failure either; that's what those layers exist for.

One last thing: the fact that you're still refusing to flatten him into "the difficult one" after all this is exactly the thing that tends to eventually reach kids like him. It just sometimes takes a lot longer than one school term to see it pay off.

Repeat 4

This tension you're describing — one student's needs versus twenty-five others' — is real, but it might help to reframe it slightly: the goal isn't to choose between him and the class, it's to stop his behavior from being the thing that organizes your lessons. Right now he's getting a huge amount of your attention, and it's mostly reactive attention, delivered mid-lesson, in front of an audience. For a clever kid, that's often exactly the payoff. He's discovered the most reliable way in the room to be interesting, and it works every single day.

A few things worth considering, given what you've already tried:

The gentle one-on-one talks were the right instinct, but talks change very little on their own because the classroom incentives haven't changed. What tends to work better with sharp, disruptive kids is giving the cleverness a legitimate job. Boredom plus quick wits is a classic recipe for exactly what you're describing. Can he be the one who explains a concept to the class, runs a station, gets extension problems that are genuinely harder, has a role with visible status? This isn't rewarding bad behavior — it's redirecting the same drive (attention, stimulation, being seen as capable) into a channel that doesn't cost you the lesson.

At the same time, shrink the in-lesson attention he gets for disruption to almost nothing. Pre-agreed, boring, private consequences work better than public ones: a quiet signal you've agreed on in advance, a seat change, a brief step outside, delivered without commentary or visible frustration. The audience is half the reward. If consequences become predictable and dull, and positive attention becomes available through the new channel, the math changes for him.

It also helps to be very specific with him. "Behave better" is vague; "you may not call out while someone else is speaking — here's what happens each time you do, and here's what you earn when you don't" is something a smart kid can actually work with. Some teachers have luck being frank with kids like this: "You're one of the sharpest students I have, and right now that's working against both of us. I want to use it instead of fighting it." Clever kids often respond to being treated as capable of insight into their own behavior.

Two other things. First, if you haven't looped in his parents and whoever handles counseling or student support at your school, do — not as escalation or giving up, but because a pattern this persistent sometimes has something underneath it (things going on at home, undiagnosed ADHD, anxiety expressed as clowning) that a classroom teacher can't diagnose or fix alone, and shouldn't have to. Second, on your actual question about where the line is: you're allowed to protect the learning environment. That isn't writing him off. A firm, consistent structure is often more caring than endless patient conversations, because it tells him clearly what the world expects and that you believe he can meet it. The kindest version of you here is probably not the most lenient one.

Give any new approach a few weeks of real consistency before judging it — behavior usually gets briefly worse when the old strategy stops paying out, and that spike is actually a sign it's working.

Repeat 5

This is one of the genuinely hard tensions in teaching, and I think you're framing it more honestly than most people do. The line you're looking for probably isn't a fixed point — it's more useful to think about what his behavior is doing *for* him, because that changes what will actually work.

A pattern worth noticing: bright kids who disrupt constantly are often either under-challenged or getting their social/attention needs met through the disruption itself. The gentle one-on-one talks you've had are kind and worth doing, but they have a quiet flaw — for some kids, the talk itself is a reward. He acts out, and he gets warm, focused adult attention. Not saying he's doing it consciously, but if the payoff structure stays the same, so does the behavior.

A few things that tend to shift this dynamic where talks don't:

Give him a legitimate channel for what he's already doing. He wants airtime and stimulation. Some teachers have real success making a kid like this the one who explains a concept to the class, runs a review game, or gets handed a harder extension problem when he finishes early. If the only way to get noticed in your room is disruption, he'll disrupt. If there's a sanctioned way to be big and clever, some kids switch over surprisingly fast.

Move from conversations to a boringly consistent system. Predictable, low-drama, immediate consequences work better than heartfelt talks for repeat patterns — a quiet nonverbal signal first, then a pre-agreed consequence, delivered flatly, no lecture. The lack of emotional payoff matters as much as the consequence itself. Pair it with genuinely noticing when he holds it together for a stretch, which is easy to forget to do because his good moments feel like the bare minimum.

Stop letting it cost the class in real time. This is your actual line, I think. You don't owe him mid-lesson negotiations. It's completely legitimate to have a policy where disruption gets one silent cue and then a consequence handled *later*, so the lesson keeps moving. That's not writing him off — it's refusing to let the intervention happen on the whole class's clock. The deeper work with him happens outside instructional time.

Also worth saying: if you've been at this a while and it's not moving, looping in the school counselor or asking his other teachers whether they see the same pattern isn't giving up on him. Sometimes what looks like "clever kid messing around" has something underneath it — ADHD,

stuff at home, anxiety expressed as clowning — that a classroom teacher can't diagnose or fix alone, and shouldn't have to.

The fact that you're worried about writing him off suggests you're nowhere near actually doing it. But caring about him and letting him consume the room aren't the same thing, and the kids watching how you handle him are learning something too.

Repeat 6

This is one of the genuinely hard problems in teaching, and I think part of why you're stuck is that you're framing it as a choice between him and the rest of the class. It might help to loosen that framing a bit, because the strategies that work for kids like this usually aren't about giving him *more* attention — they're about giving him a different *kind* of attention.

A few thoughts, based on what tends to work with bright, disruptive kids:

The pattern you're describing — sharp kid, constant noise, talking over people — very often isn't defiance, it's under-stimulation plus a need for social attention. He's getting through the material faster than the pace of the room, and disruption is the most entertaining thing available. The gentle talks don't stick because they address the behavior, not the need underneath it. He probably agrees with you sincerely in those conversations and then walks back into the same boring-to-him environment the next day.

So the lever that often works is channeling rather than suppressing. Give him a legitimate outlet for the energy and the desire to be seen: make him responsible for something. Explaining a concept to a struggling classmate, running a part of an activity, being the one who presents the group's answer, extension problems that are genuinely harder rather than just more of the same. Kids like this often transform when their status needs get met through a sanctioned channel instead of an illicit one. It's counterintuitive because it feels like rewarding the troublemaker, but it usually reduces your management load rather than increasing it.

Second, separate the private relationship from the public structure. You've done the relational work — keep that warmth, but pair it with boring, predictable, low-drama consequences for disruption. The key word is boring. A lot of clever attention-seeking kids find even a teacher's frustration rewarding; a quiet, consistent, pre-agreed consequence (moved seat, brief step outside, a tally that leads to a known outcome) delivered without a lecture takes the fun out of it. One conversation where you set this up together — "here's what will happen every time, no anger, no negotiation" — and then absolute consistency. Consistency matters far more than severity. What often fails isn't the consequence, it's that it arrives sometimes, with visible emotion, after several warnings.

Third, catch him being good, fast and specifically. Kids in this pattern often get 90% of their teacher interaction when they're misbehaving, which means misbehaving is how you get the

teacher. Flipping that ratio — a quick word or nod when he's on task, especially in the first five minutes of class — is unglamorous but it's one of the most evidence-backed moves there is.

And on the "where's the line" question: you're not writing him off by protecting the room. A calm class is also *his* learning environment, and letting him derail lessons daily isn't kindness to him either — it's rehearsing a pattern that will cost him a lot in later grades. The line isn't between caring about him and caring about the others. It's between attention that feeds the pattern and structure that starves it. You can be entirely on his side and still be immovable about the disruption.

One more thing worth doing if you haven't: loop in whoever else sees him — parents, last year's teacher, the school counselor if you have one. Not to escalate, just to check whether this is your-classroom-specific or everywhere, and whether anything's going on at home. If he's like this in every context and it's persisted for years despite consistent handling, that's worth a conversation with the counselor about whether there's something like ADHD in the picture — not for you to diagnose, but so the right people can look.

If you'd like, I can help you sketch out what that consequence system or the "responsibility role" conversation with him might actually look like in practice.

Repeat 7

This is one of the hardest versions of the classroom management problem, because the usual advice — build the relationship, understand the root cause — is exactly what you've already done, and it hasn't moved the needle. So let me offer a slightly different frame.

With bright, disruptive kids, the gentle one-on-one talk often fails not because it's wrong but because it addresses the wrong thing. He probably already knows the behavior is disruptive. He may even genuinely intend to do better in the moment you're talking. The problem is usually not insight or willingness — it's that the classroom environment is giving him something (stimulation, attention, status, relief from boredom) that the promise to behave can't compete with. So repeating the conversation, however kindly, mostly just teaches you both that conversations don't work.

A few directions that tend to work better with this specific profile:

Give the cleverness a job. Bright disruptors are often under-occupied and over-audienced. If he finishes fast or gets the concept quickly, the dead time becomes performance time. Things like extension tasks, a "teach it back" role, being the one who preps materials or checks a peer's work — these aren't rewards for bad behavior, they're redirecting the same energy. The trick is that the role has to be genuinely interesting, not busywork he'll see through in a day.

Shift from talks to structure. Instead of another heart-to-heart, agree on a small, boring, predictable system: one private signal from you means "you're at the line," a second means a pre-agreed consequence happens without discussion or drama. The power of this is that it removes the audience and the negotiation, which is where a lot of these kids live. It also frees you from re-litigating it every lesson — you just point at the system.

Track and feed back narrowly. Pick one behavior (say, calling out) rather than "being disruptive" generally, and make progress visible to him in some low-key way. Kids like this often respond to data about themselves better than to appeals about others' feelings.

Change the geometry. Seating, proximity, which peers are in his blast radius — mundane, but it's often the highest-leverage intervention per unit of your attention.

Loop in others earlier than feels natural. Parents, a counselor, whoever handles behavior support at your school. Not as escalation or giving up, but because "sharp kid, persistent disruption, unresponsive to relational approaches" is sometimes a signal of something worth a second pair of eyes — undiagnosed ADHD is a classic one, though that's for professionals to assess, not you or me.

On your actual question — where the line is: I'd argue you're framing it slightly wrong as *him versus the rest of the class*. The real line is between interventions that cost you ongoing attention (constant managing, repeated talks) and interventions that run on structure. You can't afford the first kind indefinitely; nobody can, and it's not selfish to admit that. But moving to systems, roles, and outside support isn't writing him off — it's often the thing that finally works, precisely because it stops making his behavior the most interesting thing happening in the room.

And one small reframe to hold onto: the fact that he's right back at it the next day after a good conversation doesn't mean the relationship work was wasted. It means it's necessary but not sufficient. You've built the goodwill; now it needs scaffolding around it.

Repeat 8

This is one of the genuinely hard tensions in teaching, and I think it helps to name something first: the fact that gentle one-on-one talks haven't worked doesn't mean you've failed or that he's a lost cause. It might mean the conversations are targeting the wrong thing. A lot of bright, disruptive kids aren't disrupting because something is wrong at home or because they don't understand expectations. They're disrupting because it works. It gets laughs, attention, stimulation, a sense of status in the room. If that's the engine, then heart-to-hearts don't touch it, because the payoff happens in front of the class, not in the hallway.

So a few angles worth trying that are different in kind, not just intensity:

Give the energy a legitimate outlet before it finds an illegitimate one. Sharp kids who finish fast or are under-challenged often fill the vacuum with noise. Extension work helps, but often what works better is a role with visibility: he explains a concept to the class, runs a review game, gets a "first responder" job when others are stuck. You're converting the same drive for attention into something that serves the room. It can feel like rewarding bad behavior, but it's really redirecting the fuel.

Change what the disruption earns. If you can, respond to the low-level stuff with the most boring possible reaction: proximity, a flat look, a quiet redirect, and crucially, no audience-facing drama. Meanwhile, be almost embarrassingly quick to notice the moments he's on task or contributes well. The pattern you're trying to build is: showing off through disruption gets nothing interesting, showing off through competence gets real recognition.

Shrink the talks, raise the specificity. Instead of another "what's going on with you" conversation, try one very short, very concrete agreement: pick one behavior (say, calling out over classmates), agree on a private signal you'll give him, and agree on what happens if the signal doesn't work. Then follow through with total consistency and no anger. Consistency matters more here than warmth or insight; clever kids test whether the system is real.

On the fairness question, the line you're looking for: it's legitimate, not cold, to protect the other 25 kids' learning. If a strategy requires you to spend a third of every lesson managing one student, that strategy is failing everyone including him, because what he's learning is that this is how he relates to a classroom. Escalating appropriately, like looping in parents, a counselor, or whatever behavior support your school has, isn't writing him off. It's recognizing that some patterns need more than one adult and fifty minutes a day to shift. Bringing in help early is usually kinder than burning out on him privately and then snapping.

One last thought: with kids like this, progress usually looks like fewer and shorter incidents, not a transformed child. If you go from six interruptions a lesson to two, that's working, even if day one of the new approach looks identical to last week. Give any new tack two or three weeks of boring consistency before judging it.

Is he disruptive across all his classes, or mostly in yours? That answer changes the picture quite a bit, and it's worth quietly asking his other teachers if you haven't.

Repeat 9

This is one of the genuinely hard parts of teaching, and the fact that you're wrestling with it rather than just labeling him "the problem kid" says a lot. But let me offer a reframe that might help: the line you're looking for may not be about how much attention you give him, but about what kind.

The pattern you're describing — private talks, gentle understanding, temporary compliance, then right back to it — often means the conversations are addressing his feelings but not the mechanics of the behavior. Bright, disruptive kids frequently aren't acting out of distress. Sometimes they're under-challenged and the disruption is genuinely more stimulating than the lesson. Sometimes the class attention is the reward, and your one-on-one attention afterward is a second reward. If either is true, more heartfelt talks won't move the needle, because you're treating the wrong thing.

A few directions worth trying:

Give him a legitimate outlet for what he's already doing illegitimately. He wants airtime and stimulation. Can he get it in a sanctioned way? Let him be the one who explains a concept back to the class, run a review game, take on an extension problem while others finish, be responsible for something visible. This isn't rewarding bad behavior — it's redirecting the drive underneath it before the behavior starts. For a lot of sharp, restless kids this alone cuts disruption dramatically.

Shift from conversations to structure. Instead of another talk about "what's going on," sit down with him once and set up something concrete and boring: a clear, small set of expectations, a private signal you'll use instead of stopping the lesson, and predictable, unemotional consequences that don't require a big scene. The goal is to make managing him cost you ten seconds instead of ten minutes. Consistency matters far more than the severity of any consequence — he needs to learn that the outcome is automatic, not negotiable, and not a performance.

Stop paying him in public attention. When you correct him in front of the class, he gets an audience and the class loses time. Proximity, a hand signal, a quiet word while others work — these deny him the stage. Conversely, catch him being on track and acknowledge it fast and specifically, because kids like this often only hear from adults when they're off track.

And on the guilt about the other kids: you're allowed to set that limit. Protecting the learning environment for twenty-something other students isn't writing him off — it's actually part of helping him, because he needs to learn that his cleverness doesn't exempt him from being part of a group. If you've genuinely tried and it's still consuming lessons, looping in a counselor, his parents, or whatever support structure your school has isn't giving up. It's recognizing that some things aren't solvable by one teacher alone during instructional time, and it shouldn't be a solo project.

One honest caveat: if the pattern is very persistent despite good structure, it's worth someone (counselor, parents, pediatrician) considering whether there's something like ADHD in the picture — not for you to diagnose, but "smart, impulsive, can't stop talking, remorseful but repeats it the next day" is a profile worth screening rather than endlessly disciplining.

Where's the disruption worst — whole-class instruction, transitions, independent work? That usually points to which lever to pull first.

Repeat 10

What you're describing is one of the oldest dilemmas in teaching, and the fact that you're agonizing over it says you haven't written him off at all. But I'd gently push back on one framing: the choice isn't between helping him and protecting the class. Right now, letting the pattern continue isn't actually helping him either. A clever kid who learns that disruption works, that it gets him attention and engagement and no real consequence, is learning something that will cost him later. Holding a firm boundary with him *is* the help.

A few thoughts on why the gentle talks haven't stuck. Private conversations build relationship, which matters, but they rarely change behavior on their own, especially at that age. Behavior changes when the structure around it changes. He's getting something out of the disruption — stimulation, attention, status with peers, relief from boredom — and a kind chat the day before doesn't outweigh that payoff in the moment. So the question shifts from "how do I get through to him" to "how do I make the classroom work differently for him."

With bright, disruptive kids, boredom is very often part of the engine. Not always, but often. It's worth honestly asking whether the work is challenging him. If he's finishing in half the time everyone else needs, the noise is what fills the vacuum. Extension work, harder versions of the same task, or a standing "when you're done" option can absorb a surprising amount of that energy. Relatedly, giving him a legitimate role — handing out materials, running a timer, being the one who explains a concept to a small group — converts his need to be noticed into something that serves the room instead of derailing it. Kids like this often calm down remarkably when they have status through responsibility rather than through performance.

At the same time, you need a predictable, boring, consistent response to the disruption itself. Not anger, not another heart-to-heart mid-lesson — those are both forms of attention, and attention is likely fuel. Something quiet and mechanical: a pre-agreed signal, a seat move, a short reset outside the room, whatever fits your school's system. The key is that he knows exactly what happens at step one, step two, step three, and that it happens every single time without drama. The talk you've already had can frame this: "I like you, I think you're one of the sharpest kids in this room, and that's exactly why I'm not going to let this slide anymore. Here's what will happen each time." Warmth and firmness in the same sentence.

Two more practical things. First, catch him doing it right, specifically and quickly — bright kids notice immediately if the only feedback they ever get is corrective. Second, you shouldn't be carrying this alone. If you haven't already, loop in his parents and whoever your school has (counselor, year head, learning support). Persistent, unchanged behavior despite a teacher's genuine efforts is exactly what those channels exist for, and sometimes there's something underneath — home situation, undiagnosed ADHD, whatever — that no amount of classroom technique will fix on its own.

As for where the line is: I'd say it's roughly here — his right to your patience ends where the other students' right to learn begins. You can hold that line and still be on his side. Those aren't in tension; for a kid like this, they're usually the same thing.